GRAMMAR 1: WORDS AND WORD FORMS

Very often when we write, we have to choose which word best expresses the idea we want to convey. When we do this, we need to consider three things about a particular word:

- The **meaning** of the word (e.g., do we want to say "assess" or "access," "borrow" or "lend")
- The **form** of the word so that it expresses our idea accurately and correctly (e.g., should we say "effective" or "effectively," "economic" or "economics")
- The **function** of the word in a clause/sentence (e.g., is it the subject or the predicate)

Of these three things, it is the form and function of a word which often influences the grammaticality of a clause/sentence.

Word Forms

The most commonly used word forms are **nouns, verbs**, **adjectives**, and **adverbs**. The table below shows the differences between these forms. (Some nouns can be changed into verbs by changing their stress patterns; for example, 'record, a noun and re'cord a verb.)

Word Form	Definition	Examples
Noun	To name a person, place, thing or idea	John, university, car, democracy, idea
Verb	To show an action or state of being	eat, is/are, attend, provide, adjust, seem
Adjective	To describe the qualities of a noun	beautiful, hot, difficult, smooth, convenient
Adverb	To add meanings to verbs (usually in terms of direction, location, manner, time and frequency), adjectives, or other adverbs in a sentence	there, internationally, slowly, soon, frequently, very

Exercise 1: Identifying Word Forms

Below is a list of words. On the space beside each word, indicate whether it is a noun, verb, adjective or adverb. The first word has been done for you. (Note that some words can be classified as both a noun and a verb.)

1. temperature _____*noun*_____
2. specify _____
3. research _____
4. continually _____
5. understandable _____
6. inquire _____
7. eligibility _____

8. lengthen _____
9. specialist _____
10. frequently _____
11. characterize _____
12. distinction _____
13. appropriate _____
14. relationship _____
15. tentatively _____
16. friendly _____

Word Functions

Based on the **function** they have within a sentence, words can be classified as **subjects**, **objects**, **predicates**, **attributives**, and **adverbials** of the sentence. The table below shows the differences between these functions.

Function	Definition	Examples
Subject	Noun(s) which is being talked about or doing the action in the sentence	▪ **John** reads important documents very carefully. ▪ Every year the **university** accepts many international students.
Object	Noun(s) which is affected by the action of a verb	▪ John reads important **document**s very carefully. ▪ Every year the university accepts many international **students**.
Predicate (Verb)	Word(s) which shows the "action" or state of being of the subject	▪ John **reads** important documents very carefully. ▪ Every year the university **accepts** many international students.
Attributive (Adjective)	Word(s) which describes the qualities of the subject or object	▪ John reads **important** documents very carefully. ▪ Every year the university accepts **many international** students.
Adverbial (Adverb)	Word(s) which adds meanings to verbs (usually in terms of direction, location, manner, time and frequency), adjectives, or other adverbs in the sentence	▪ John reads important documents **very carefully**. ▪ **Every year** the university accepts many international students.

It is important to know what form of the word you should use in your sentence to avoid grammar mistakes. This is because each form can be used only in particular ways in a sentence. Here are some basic word form rules to remember:

1. Only nouns (or a string of words referring to a noun) or pronouns can be used as subjects or objects in a sentence.

    - **Beauty** is valued in the entertainment business.
    - **The beauty of nature** cannot be replaced.
    - **She** found **beauty** in the child's smile.

2. Only adjectives (or a string of words describing a quality) can be used to describe a subject or object in a sentence.

    - Nature is **beautiful**.
    - The **big** house burned down yesterday.
    - She found the **colorful** cloth in that store.

3. Adverbs (or a string of words that behave as an adverb) describe only verbs, adjectives or other adverbs.

    - Her mother sings **beautifully**.
    - The thief stole an **extremely** expensive watch.
    - He **very kindly** gave her the information.

The following sentences used the wrong word forms:

*****Competitive*** *is valued in the entertainment business. (competitiveness)*
The wanton* ***destruct* *of nature cannot be allowed. (destruction)*

Common Word Suffixes

A suffix is the end part of a word that can be added to signal a change in its form and/or meaning. Being familiar with some common English suffixes will help you determine whether a word is a noun, a verb, an adjective or an adverb, and consequently how to use it in a sentence.

Exercise 2: Study the suffixes and examples. Then add your own example in the space provided.

Noun Suffixes

- ment	argument	establishment	
- ness	sadness	shyness	
- tion	application	indication	
- sion	expression	admission	
- ity	legibility	impossibility	
- ence	difference	excellence	
- ance	importance	distance	
- ure	departure	failure	
- er	teacher	speaker	

- ism	socialism	sexism	
- ist	specialist	typist	
- ship	scholarship	friendship	

Verb Suffixes

- ate	mediate	delegate	
- en	lengthen	sharpen	
- ify	solidify	quantify	
- ize	finalize	customize	

Adjective Suffixes

- ous	dangerous	famous	
- ful	colorful	useful	
- less	colorless	useless	
- ive	expressive	competitive	
- able	agreeable	understandable	
- ent	sufficient	excellent	
- ant	important	hesitant	
- ic	characteristic	economic	
- al	emotional	musical	
- some	troublesome	bothersome	
- ate	considerate	subordinate	
- y	dressy	noisy	
- ly	friendly	lonely	
- like	childlike	lifelike	
- an	Italian	American	
- ese	Japanese	Vietnamese	
- ing	interesting	challenging	
- ed	interested	challenged	

Adverb Suffix

- ly	usually	legibly	

Exercise 3: Using Correct Word Forms in Sentences

In each sentence below, the incorrect form of a word is used. Underline this incorrect form, identify the kind of word it is (noun, adjective, verb, etc.) and then write the correct form of that word and what kind of word it is in the spaces provided. Read the example first.

Example: The man ran **quick**. adjective **quickly (adverb)**

1. The different between A and B is great. _____ _____
2. Efficiency is importantly. _____ _____
3. The economic is doing badly. _____ _____
4. We decision wisely. _____ _____
5. Prof Li emphasis punctuality in class. _____ _____
6. The teams compete fierce. _____ _____
7. The teacher praised his students frequent. _____ _____
8. He made his mother very happily. _____ _____
9. This book is bored. _____ _____
10. She saw sad in the child's eyes. _____ _____

Exercise 4: Using Correct Word Forms in Paragraphs (errors identified)

The paragraph below describes survey data obtained from parents and teachers in an elementary school. The paragraph contains errors in word forms. Each word-form error is underlined. Write the correct form of the word above it.

Teachers and parents generally do not have similarly perceptions about what influences child behaviour most. In particular, this behaviour includes personality, intelligent, learning difficulties and mental illness. Obviously, the most significant different between teachers and parents lies in the area of personality. Most parents belief that the influence of genes is greater than that of the environment. On the other hand, most teachers tendency to think the influence of these two factors is equal. The reason why more parents tend to emphasis the influence of genes may be that they spend more time with their own children than teachers do.

Exercise 5: Using Correct Word Forms in Paragraphs (errors not identified)

The next paragraph is about how one adjusts to living in a foreign culture. There are nine word-form errors in it, but these are not identified. Underline the errors and write the correct form of the word above it.

> After getting over the initially shock of living abroad, you may settle down in your new environment. If you decision to stay, you eventually learn to deal with the different between your own culture and that of your new home. You begin to learn the language and make more friends. You may start to integrate your own beliefs with those of the new cultural. You may still have the occasion crisis, but you have a positively attitude towards it. Maybe you can even laugh about your difficult! This period of adjust can happen slow, and it is always possible to go back into shock again.

Adapted from:

Lane, J. & Lange, E. (1999). *Writing clearly: An editing guide* (2nd ed.), Boston: Heinle & Heinle.